

CHAPTER 25 — Old Routes

The first thing Zoe learned about conspiracies was that they still had checkout times.

At eight forty-five, someone knocked on the hotel door.

Three short taps.

A pause.

Then two more.

Zoe sat upright so quickly the paperback fell from the bed.

Elias was already standing.

Of course he was.

His hand did not go to the gun first. It went to the curtain.

Another knock.

“Housekeeping.”

Zoe stared at him.

Elias stared at the door.

“Terrifying,” she whispered.

He glanced back. “You joke when you’re frightened.”

“You stare at curtains.”

“Effective curtains.”

The woman knocked again.

Elias opened the door with the chain still on.

“No service, thanks.”

“You’re checking out by ten.”

“That’s right.”

“Reception says key card back at desk.”

He nodded.

The woman looked through the gap, not enough to see much.

“Need towels?”

“No.”

“Yes,” Zoe called from the bed.

Elias looked at her.

“We used the towels.”

“That is generally why hotels wash them.”

The cleaner passed two folded towels through the gap. Elias thanked her, closed the door and locked it.

Zoe held one up.

“Useful.”

“We’re leaving.”

“Still useful.”

She dropped it beside the backpack.

The original drive was inside. So was the folder. Elias had the working copy. The second copy was sealed in the padded envelope on the desk.

Three versions of the same danger.

Zoe looked at the envelope.

“Where does that go?”

“The place we agreed.”

“You said we’d check it first.”

“I did.”

“When?”

"Six thirty."

Her head snapped round.

"You left?"

"For fourteen minutes."

"You said next time you wake me."

"For decisions."

"You leaving is a decision."

"It was a route check."

"That required leaving."

He stopped.

Zoe waited.

Elias rubbed the back of his neck. He looked tired enough that the movement seemed to belong to someone much older.

"You're right."

No explanation.

No defence.

She hated how effective that was.

"You could at least make arguing harder."

"I'll work on it."

"Where?"

"The backup?"

She nodded.

"A locked document box inside a twenty-four-hour print shop."

Zoe lowered the paperback.

"That sounds made up."

"It isn't."

"People put documents in boxes at print shops?"

"Businesses do."

"Why?"

"Because businesses remain strangely committed to paper."

"And we can get it back?"

"With the retrieval code."

"Who has the code?"

"You and me."

"You wrote it down?"

"No."

Zoe studied him. "So we're relying on your memory."

"And yours."

"That's worse."

He almost smiled. So did she. Then the envelope caught her eye again and the smile disappeared. Nothing about a stolen archive should have been funny. Still, some things were. Maybe they had to be. She put the paperback into the backpack. "Show me the routes."

Elias checked the clock. "We have forty-five minutes."

"Plenty."

"For what?"

"International criminal organisation."

"Forty."

"Fine."

He opened the old laptop.

* * *

The machine took longer to wake than Zoe did.

By the time the plain desktop appeared, she had already pulled the notebook across the bed.

Nothing on the laptop knew the outside world existed.

No Wi-Fi. No messages. No weather. No news.

Zoe liked that.

Elias opened the working copy.

Yesterday, the index had looked like a wall.

Today it looked slightly less like one.

That worried her more.

She searched her own number.

A17-04221

Four actions.

Placement.

Monitor.

Recover.

Exception.

Her old placement carried one route code.

N4-7

The recent recovery carried another.

E2-4

She wrote both.

"Yesterday you said we didn't know what they meant."

"We don't."

"Then let's find out what they do."

Elias looked at her.

"Better question."

She searched N4-7.

The count appeared.

118 actions.

Zoe sat back.

"That's a lot."

The full list was messy, but the pattern was not.

Placements.

Transfers.

Assessments.

Monitoring.

Recoveries.

And twenty-two returns.

Zoe stopped there.

"Return."

She opened one.

Different number. Different account. Different year.

Closed. Another return. Closed. A third had been marked temporary before being returned. "What does TEMP mean?"

"Temporary is the obvious answer."

"You're allowed to say obvious now?"

"When it is."

She clicked through more. Placement. Closed. Transfer. Closed. Recover. Closed. The route was not behaving the way she wanted it to. The archive had come from Cain. Cain held children. Mac had bought her. Therefore every line inside Cain's drive should have been bad. That was much easier. "What if RETURN means returned to them?" she asked.

"Could."

"Cain."

"Maybe."

She looked at him. "That's not what you think."

Elias leaned closer to the screen. "No. I think this route is doing too many ordinary things."

"Ordinary for what?"

"Safeguarding. Placements. Transfers. Children going back."

"Maybe that's camouflage."

"Maybe."

She glared.

He pointed at the closed rows.

"Or maybe they didn't build the whole thing."

Zoe looked at him.

"What do you mean?"

"They may be using something that was already real."

The thought landed differently.

A criminal route was simple.

Bad road. Bad people. Bad destination.

A real road used for bad things was worse.

She searched E2-4.

41 actions.

Much smaller.

Mostly recoveries, transfers and holds.

Only two returns.

Both unresolved.

Zoe wrote the numbers down.

"N4-7 is everything."

"Broad."

"E2-4 looks uglier."

"It looks narrower."

"Same thing."

"No."

"You make words boring on purpose."

"Useful skill."

She circled both codes.

"What if they're places?"

"Could be."

"Region four, route seven?"

Elias shrugged.

"North four dash seven?"

"You're making the letters work very hard."

"Network four—"

“Stop.”

She smiled.

Then took the intermediary sheet from the folder.

Coffee stain. Fold lines. Four names. Two companies. A solicitor. A vehicle supplier.

Halfway down:

Meridian Placement Services Ltd.

The name was also in Zoe’s paper folder, printed above a transfer certification.

It sounded like a company with a website full of smiling stock photographs and people pointing at clipboards.

“What did Vale say Meridian did?”

“Document processing.”

“Then why call it Placement Services?”

“Ask the person who named it.”

“Helpful.”

She searched MERIDIAN.

Nothing.

She tried the company number.

Nothing.

“Not in here.”

“Not plainly.”

“Because names are too easy?”

“Probably.”

“For us?”

“For anyone.”

Zoe looked at the index again.

“Still useful.”

She opened the notebook.

At first she wrote:

ROUTE DOES NOT = CRIME

Then stared at it.

Too neat.

She crossed it out.

Underneath she wrote:

same route doesn't mean same thing Then:

find one we KNOW was normal

Elias read it.

This time he did not say good.

Zoe appreciated that.

“Coat,” she said.

He looked away.

* * *

At nine twenty-three, Voss found the first match in a folder marked 2019.

Paper.

Vale had laughed at him for keeping paper until an encrypted drive died in a Rotterdam hotel and he produced six years of contact histories from a waterproof case.

She had never admitted he had been right.

That would have damaged the natural order.

The rented room above the closed estate office had become less temporary overnight.

Two takeaway cups stood beside the window.

Vale's coat hung from the chair.

Three old job files lay open across the desk.

Reyes's chair did not exist.

Voss had noticed that twice.

He disliked himself for noticing.

Vale sat on the floor with her back against the wall.

"Again."

Voss read.

"North district emergency transfer. Female minor. Ten years old. Removal following prohibited parental contact."

"Client?"

"Local authority subcontract through Westmere Child Safeguarding."

"Verified?"

"At the time."

"How?"

"Order number checked. Duty contact confirmed the case was active. Vehicle collected from approved placement."

"Destination?"

He read it.

Vale closed her eyes for half a second.

"I remember."

"So do I."

The girl had screamed for twenty minutes.

Not at them.

At the house.

She had wrapped both hands around a stair rail while two carers loosened her fingers one by one.

The order said her mother had breached contact restrictions.

The girl said her mother was waiting at court.

Voss had treated it as distress.

Children in custody disputes said things.

Adults did too.

His job had been to move the person named on the order.

He looked at the route line.

N4/7

Different punctuation.

Same shape.

Vale stood.

"Show me."

He turned the page.

She read it, then crossed to another file.

"Portsmouth."

"Year?"

"Twenty twenty-one."

Adult male.

No child.

Witness relocation after threats connected to a trafficking prosecution.

Real police liaison.

Real court order.

Real identity change.

Vale found the movement sheet.

N4/7

She put both pages together.

"Same route family."

Voss nodded.

"One definitely legitimate."

"Yes."

"The girl?"

"We believed it was."

Vale looked at him.

"That's not an answer."

"No."

She reached for a third file.

Fourteen-year-old boy.

Recovery from a supposed non-custodial father.

The father had not been there when they arrived.

The boy had.

He refused shoes.

Reyes carried them because the child would not put them on and then

complained for forty miles that the laces kept slipping under the passenger seat.

Vale remembered stupid things now.

Coffee.

Mints.

Shoes.

She found the routing page.

E2/4

Vale stopped.

Voss took off his glasses and cleaned them.

They did not need cleaning.

"Client?" she asked.

"Private recovery instruction through Meridian."

"The same Meridian?"

"Same."

"External check?"

He read the form.

Blank.

Vale took it from him.

"You accepted that?"

"Reyes made local contact."

"With who?"

"The number on the order."

Vale's expression changed.

"That's not what I asked."

Voss checked the notes.

A phone number.

Initials.

No institution.

"No separate contact."

Vale put the paper down carefully.

The care made the anger more obvious.

"We checked the document against the person whose number was printed on the document."

Voss said nothing.

"That isn't verification."

"No."

"But we treated it as verification."

"At the time."

Vale turned towards the rain beginning against the window.

"Why?"

He knew what she meant.

Not the rain.

Why it had been enough.

Voss looked at the file.

"Regular intermediary. Payment was normal. Paperwork looked right. The child was already in a recognised placement property. Professional staff were there. Vehicle authority matched the job."

Vale listened.

"No one asked us to kidnap somebody from a playground."

"No."

She laughed once.

Nothing amused in it.

"That's the trick."

Voss looked at the two route sheets.

One definitely legitimate.

One no longer comfortable.

"The route isn't the criminal part," Vale said.

"Not by itself."

"It's transport."

"Looks that way."

Vale leaned over the desk.

"Then what changes?"

Voss looked at the paperwork.

"The instruction."

* * *

Zoe did not like the word RETURN.

It made everything untidy.

She preferred villains who labelled things properly.

Elias declined to acknowledge this as a reasonable administrative standard.

They checked out at nine fifty-two. At reception: "Everything all right with the room?"

Elias handed over the key card. "Fine."

Zoe looked at the floor. "The carpet is hostile."

The receptionist looked down automatically. "It's being replaced next year."

"Good."

Outside, the rain had stopped. The city had washed itself grey. They walked separately at first, then together. No obvious tail. No repeated face. No vehicle that survived three turns. Elias bought toothbrushes at a chemist. Zoe made him buy the wiper blades. "Wrong car," he said.

"They'll fit something."

"That is not how wiper blades work."

"You said we need a new car."

"Eventually."

"Buy one that fits the blades."

He stared at her.

"Your planning has become aggressive."

"Efficient."

They changed buses twice, crossed an indoor shopping centre and left through a department store.

At eleven seventeen, the second archive copy went into the document box.

Elias entered the retrieval code.

Zoe entered it separately.

The lock clicked.

No names.

No phones.

No single mistake could now destroy every copy.

Zoe liked that.

She disliked needing to like it.

* * *

They spent the afternoon in a public library.

Not because libraries were safe.

Because nobody looked strange carrying a notebook in one.

The old laptop stayed packed away.

Today they were not going to search the archive again.

Today they were going to work out what could exist outside it.

Zoe sat between shelves marked LOCAL HISTORY and BUSINESS.

A man slept behind a newspaper nearby.

A university student had arranged six coloured pens around a laptop with military precision.

Two children whispered loudly over a dinosaur book while their mother told them to use inside voices.

Zoe watched them a second too long. Then looked down at the notebook. "What counts as normal?"

Elias glanced up. "In what sense?"

"The route. We need one we know was real."

"We need something outside the drive."

"So pick one of the returns."

"We don't have names."

"Voss might."

"If we could contact him safely."

"We can't."

"Not yet."

Zoe turned the intermediary sheet over. "Solicitor?"

"Too close to Voss's channel."

"Vehicle company?"

"Same problem."

"Meridian?"

"Definitely not."

"So the whole list is useless."

"It tells us where not to ask questions."

"That's an annoying kind of useful."

"Often is."

She stared at the sheet.

"What would a real case leave behind?"

Elias thought about it.

"A court order, maybe. Local-authority record. School or medical changes."

"Those could still exist if the case was fake."

"Exactly."

Zoe frowned.

"Then how do you tell?"

"Find something the people on the paperwork didn't control."

She tapped the pen against the table.

"Like calling a court from the public number instead of the one printed on the order."

Elias looked at her.

"Yes."

She did not need the answer.

She had already heard it in her own sentence.

Zoe wrote:

check somewhere else Then:

public records / company filings / property

"No kids," she said.

"No kids."

"No parents unless we have to."

"Agreed."

She underlined the first line twice.

* * *

At four twelve, Vale found the fourth N4/7 file.

This one was unquestionably ordinary.

Twelve-year-old boy.

Emergency accommodation to grandmother after his mother entered hospital.

No secrecy.

No dispute.

Grandmother signed at collection.

Local authority followed up forty-eight hours later.

Reyes had worked the job.

Vale remembered the grandmother giving him a bag of apples from her garden.

He complained that six apples were a strange gratuity.

Then ate four before they reached the motorway.

N4/7.

Legitimate.

The fifth file was different.

Nine-year-old girl.

Temporary safeguarding.

Mother in residential treatment.

Expected reunification within six months.

Vale read on.

Three transfers.

Then recovery.

Then permanent reassignment.

No return.

No explanation in Voss's notes.

The client changed midway through. The original instruction came through a local-authority subcontract. The recovery came through Meridian. Same child. Same route family. Different chain. "Voss."

He looked up. She turned the papers towards him. "Same subject."

He read them. The first placement looked ordinary. The later recovery did not come from the same authority. "Did we verify the second order?"

Vale already knew. "No."

Voss found the contact note. The number printed on the recovery paperwork had been called. A man calling himself court administration confirmed the order. Nothing else. No court switchboard. No local-authority callback. No independent solicitor. At the time, the document had everything it needed. Case number.

Crest. Judge's name. Signature. Correct language. The child was already inside the safeguarding system. Nothing looked like a kidnapping. That was why nobody treated it as one. Vale sat opposite him. "What happened to her?"

Voss turned the last page. Their involvement ended at delivery. "No record."

"Can we find out?"

"Probably."

"Without alerting the same people?"

Voss looked at the case number. "Not through anything printed here."

He copied the case number onto clean paper. Then the court. Then the judge. Vale watched him. "External check."

"Yes."

"You said we were out."

"We are."

"This looks very much like in." "No." "What does it look like?" Voss capped the pen. "Finding out whether we moved a child on a real order." Vale's eyes stayed on him. "And if we didn't?" Voss did not answer. The answer would not change the job. Only what they did next.

* * *

At six, Zoe and Elias checked into another hotel. Different chain. Different part of the city. One room. Two beds. No breakfast. Zoe approved the carpet. Elias wisely did not ask why. The working copy stayed packed away. That had been the agreement. One day of questions outside the archive. Zoe sat by the window while traffic moved below. She had spent most of her life thinking systems were things adults understood. School.

Hospitals.

Police.

Courts.

Adoption.

Safeguarding.

Forms. Rules. Identification cards. Logos on doors.

People told you somebody had authority and you were supposed to believe them because there was a building behind them.

Cain's house had been simpler.

Nobody there pretended she was free.

The thought arrived without warning.

"If some of it is real," she said.

Elias was replacing the blade on a disposable razor.

He stopped.

"The organisation."

He waited.

"If some of it is normal... then the bad part doesn't need its own cars."

"No."

"Or houses."

"No."

"Or people."

"Some of them might not even know."

Zoe looked down at the street.

"That's worse."

"In some ways."

"If Cain drove around in a van with CHILD KIDNAPPING written on the side, somebody would notice."

"Probably."

“But if someone turns up with a court order—”

“The person reading it may obey it.”

“And if they call the number printed on the order to check?”

Elias looked at her.

“Then the lie checks itself.”

Zoe turned.

The sentence stayed in the room.

She opened the notebook.

THE LIE CHECKS ITSELF

She stared at it, crossed out CHECKS and wrote:

THE LIE VERIFIES ITSELF

Then underneath:

unless you check somewhere it doesn't control

That word, verifies, sounded adult.

She left it anyway.

Elias had used it before. She knew what it meant now.

“What if that's what the drive is?” she asked.

“What?”

“Not the whole fake system.”

She searched for the words.

“The bit that tells the fake part where to touch the real one.”

Elias sat on the edge of the second bed.

“Could be.”

Zoe shot him a look.

He lifted one hand.

"That was deserved."

She looked back at the notebook.

"It would explain why some routes are normal."

"And why Voss could have done real jobs and bad ones without seeing the difference."

"And why Helen and Brian could have paperwork."

Elias did not answer.

Zoe noticed.

"They had paperwork."

"Yes."

"Fake."

"Your folder does not contain a lawful adoption order."

"That's not the same as them knowing."

"No."

Maybe they thought it was real.

Maybe somebody lied to them.

Maybe they knew enough.

Maybe they loved her.

Maybe love made everything worse instead of better.

The questions crowded each other.

Zoe closed the notebook.

"Not yet."

Elias let it go.

That was one of the better things he had learned.

* * *

At seven thirty-seven, Voss called the court. Not the number on the old recovery order. The public switchboard. He gave no child's name. Only the historic case number and the judge shown on the page. The clerk put him on hold. Vale stood near the window. Music played that seemed designed to punish anyone trying to do the right thing. The clerk returned. "Can you repeat the reference?"

He did. Keyboard sounds. Another pause. "I don't have that reference in this court."

"Could it have been transferred?"

"What year?" He told her.

More typing. "What judge?"

Voss gave the name. The typing stopped. "That judge wasn't sitting family cases here that year."

Voss looked at Vale.

Her expression did not change. "Are you certain?"

"Yes."

"Emergency order? Out of hours?"

"There would still be a record."

Voss looked at the photocopy. Crest. Case number. Judge. Signature. Everything where it should have been. "Thank you."

He ended the call. Vale waited. "No case," he said.

"The judge?"

"Wrong jurisdiction that year."

Vale sat down. Neither spoke for several seconds. Then: "What was the girl's name?"

Voss looked at the file. The name had been there the whole time. He

had avoided saying it. Names made old jobs present.

He read it aloud.

Vale closed her eyes.

"Do you remember her?"

"No."

"I do."

Voss waited.

"Yellow coat."

That was all.

It was enough.

On the table sat one legitimate N4/7 route.

One questionable E2/4 recovery.

And one child who had entered the system legitimately before being moved on paperwork a real court had never issued.

The road had not changed.

The authority had.

Voss turned to a clean page.

At the top he wrote:

NORMAL

Underneath:

OVERRIDE

Vale looked at it.

"You think that's the point?"

"I think that's what we need to find."

Outside, traffic passed beneath the window.

Ordinary.

Unaware.

For years Voss had thought the dangerous part of the job began when somebody resisted.

A door.

A vehicle.

A weapon.

Someone refusing to move.

He had been wrong.

Sometimes the dangerous part happened much earlier.

Someone changed a line on a piece of paper.

Everybody after that did their job.

* * *

Zoe was asleep when Elias wrote the same word.

Not because he knew what Voss had found.

Because the pattern left fewer places to look.

He sat at the hotel desk.

He did not write in Zoe's notebook.

On the back of the hotel receipt he wrote:

NORMAL

OVERRIDE

Then underneath:

Need a case that changes pathway.

He stopped there.

Across the room, Zoe slept facing the wall.

The backpack rested beside the bed.

Not between them.

Elias folded the receipt once and placed it under his wallet.

The same roads could carry lawful children and stolen ones.

So the road proved nothing.

The moment somebody changed the direction was where they had to look.